

From Manager to *Director*.

Ten steps, two to five years. The jump is not a harder version of your current job — it is a **change of category**. Managers are paid to deliver. Directors are paid to originate, own revenue and pull the whole firm onto an account. Everything below is built around that single discontinuity.

THE CLIMB

● Manager	YOU ARE HERE
● Senior Manager	THE WALL • 2-4 YRS
● Director	THE TARGET
● Associate Partner	2-4 yrs
● Partner	elected

YEAR 0 - 1 • POSITION

Be named, be narrow

Declare the ambition, choose the niche, recruit the people who will argue for you. Steps 1-3.

YEAR 1 - 3 • BUILD

Move the mix, build the book

Convert delivery hours into origination hours and revenue that carries your name. Steps 4-7.

YEAR 3 - 5 • CONVERT

Make the case unarguable

Evidence, headroom, timing — and a hard review date you actually honour. Steps 8-10.

1 DECLARE

Say it out loud, in writing, this cycle

Ambition kept private does not exist. Put **Director** into your LEAD goals, say it to your counsellor and your service-line leader in the same month, and ask the one question most people avoid: **what specifically is missing?** A pipeline you are not named in never considers you — and roughly 60% of EY partner appointments come from inside, so the pipeline is real.

Ask for the gap list. Get it in writing.

3 SPONSOR

Recruit the person who spends capital on you

A mentor gives you advice; a **sponsor argues for you in rooms you will never enter** — that is the trapdoor that opens. Sponsored people are ~23% more likely to be promoted and earn ~12% more. Then widen it: one advocate is a single point of failure. Build three to five partners who can each quote a real number you produced.

1 sponsor + 3-5 partners who can cite your numbers

5 REVENUE

Get a number with your name on it

Directors are judged on **owned revenue and pipeline**, not effort or excellence. Move your language — and your reality — from "I delivered on that account" to "that account is mine". Track origination, managed revenue and conversion monthly — Director bands commonly sit near ~\$1.75m of managed revenue with a matching cross-sell target.

Own the P&L of one account or capability

7 BENCH

Build the person who replaces you

You cannot be promoted out of a seat **nobody else can fill**. Grow two Managers who can run delivery without you, and let them be seen doing it in front of partners. Successor risk is a quiet, rarely-stated reason strong cases get deferred a year — remove it before anyone has to raise it.

2 named successors, proven on live engagements

9 HEADROOM

Go where the firm is short, not where it is crowded

Your personal case is only half the decision. The firm must believe **the seat pays for itself**. Aim at demand the leadership has already funded — AI, energy transition, private capital, regulatory change — or a geography willing to open a new Director slot. Mobility converts cases that merit alone will not.

Choose a practice with a gap, not a queue

2 NARROW

Own one intersection, not five

Pick a **sector × capability** pairing tight enough that you are the first call in the firm — not "data", but "AI assurance for insurers". Directors are bought, not applied for: the market must ask for you by name. Generalists are useful at Manager and invisible at Director, because breadth cannot be sold, only depth can.

Target: top-3 recognised name in one niche

4 MIX

Move from 80/20 delivery to 60/40 by year two

Being superb at delivery is the **single most common way to get trapped in it**. The firm has every incentive to keep you billing; nobody will hand you origination time. Block it like a client meeting, defend it like one, and accept that the skills that made you an excellent Manager are not the ones now being assessed.

~2 days a week on origination by end of Y2

6 CROSS-SELL

Bring the whole firm, not your team

The distinguishing Director test is whether you can pull **Tax, Consulting, Strategy & Transactions and Assurance** into your accounts. Learn the neighbouring service lines well enough to recognise their work inside your client's problems — then make the introduction before they ask. Cross-sell is the metric that separates a very good Senior Manager from a Director.

3+ service lines introduced per key account

8 CASE

Write the business case three years early

Submission windows are often a **single week** — the case cannot be written then, only retrieved. Keep a live one-pager and lead every line with attribution: "Led the pricing review that recovered £4.2m in margin", not "was involved in". Committees allocate you less credit than you assume, so claim precisely and name your supporters.

Refresh quarterly, before every counsellor conversation

10 DEADLINE

Set a decision date and honour it

Give it **two full promotion cycles** after you are formally in the pipeline. If you are not nominated, not sponsored, and the answer never becomes specific, that is the answer. A lateral move into a rival at the next grade is the standard accelerator, and it resets both the personal and the business case at once.

Hard review point: two cycles, then decide

GATE 1 - PERSONAL CASE

Can you do the job? Delivery excellence, ratings, leadership, a visible niche. Necessary, and on its own never sufficient.

GATE 2 - BUSINESS CASE

Does the seat pay for itself? Owned revenue, pipeline, cross-sell, a market with funded headroom.

GATE 3 - POLITICAL CASE

Who argues for you in the room? One sponsor with capital, several partners who can quote your numbers.

The clock. Two to four years Manager → Senior Manager, two to four again to Director; compressing it means over-delivering on gates 2 and 3 years before anyone asks for them. **The failure mode is never effort** — it is a brilliant deliverer with no book, no sponsor and no niche, waiting to be noticed by a process that does not work that way.

SOURCES • EY UK grade structure & partner-appointment disclosures • Big 4 partner-promotion research (Townsend) • Hewlett, sponsorship effect • practitioner reporting on Big 4 managed-revenue targets